

Harmonic orbs

Enigma Factsheet · Harmonic orbs

When you determine the size of the orbs of aspects on the basis of harmonics, you are talking about harmonic orbs. This idea was introduced by John Addey and later developed further by, among others, Albert Bredenhoff.

Harmonics and aspects

Aspects divide the circle of the zodiac and, in that sense, resemble harmonics. For example, the square corresponds to the fourth harmonic: both divide the circle into four parts of 90 degrees. Likewise, the trine matches the third harmonic, and so on.

This led to the idea that the orbs of the aspects also depend on harmonics. You then start from a base orb and, for each harmonic/aspect, you take a fraction of that base orb.

You begin with a base orb, the orb you would normally use for a conjunction. Next, you determine which harmonic an aspect belongs to. That is easy for some of the aspects. For instance, the opposition equals the second harmonic and the trine the third harmonic. But some aspects cannot be obtained by dividing the circle by a whole number, for example the sesquiquadrate ($\frac{3}{8}$ of a circle) and the inconjunct ($\frac{5}{6}$ of a circle).

In those cases you look at the underlying aspect: a sesquiquadrate consists of 3 semi-squares. A semi-square corresponds to the eighth harmonic ($\frac{1}{8}$ of the circle), and that therefore also applies to the sesquiquadrate. The same holds for the inconjunct. That aspect consists of 5 semi-sextiles, which correspond to the 12th harmonic.

The base orb

The most important choice you have to make is that of the base orb. You cannot make it too wide, otherwise you run the risk that the orbs of different aspects overlap one another. Between the inconjunct and the biquintile, for example, there is only a 6-degree difference; the combined orb of both aspects must therefore be smaller than 6 degrees. Bredenhoff proposes using 15 degrees as the maximum base orb. That guarantees that there are no overlaps for aspects that you base on the first 12 harmonics. But a smaller base orb is also possible.



1. Addey, John. *Harmonics in Astrology*. Fromes, 1976, reprint 2002.
2. Bredenhoff, Albert. *Harmonische Aspecten-Analyse*. Hattem, 1986.